

100 Days of Linux - Day 052

Title: Working with Web Requests using curl

Today's Goal

Learn how to retrieve web pages, inspect HTTP headers, call REST APIs, and download data using the **curl** command.

Why This Matters

Developers and data engineers use curl every day to test APIs, download files, check web services, and troubleshoot network issues.

Command of the Day: curl

Common Syntax:

```
curl https://example.com
curl -I https://example.com (headers only)
curl -o page.html https://example.com (save output)
curl https://api.github.com
```

Common Options:

- I = Fetch HTTP headers only
- o = Save output to a file
- O = Save using the remote filename
- L = Follow redirects

Beginner Lesson

curl sends requests to web servers. You can use it to view web pages, download files, or test APIs directly from the terminal without opening a browser.

Practice Questions

1. Use curl to retrieve the HTML content of `https://example.com`.
2. Display only the HTTP response headers for `https://example.com`.
3. Download the HTML page from `https://example.com` and save it as `example.html`.
4. Use curl to fetch data from `https://api.github.com` and observe the JSON response.
5. Display your current working directory after completing today's tasks.

Hints

If a website redirects to another URL, use the -L option so curl follows the redirect automatically.

Mini Challenge

Download the home page of two different websites into separate HTML files. Compare their file sizes using `ls -lh` and count their lines with `wc -l`.

Common Mistakes

Forgetting quotes around URLs that contain special characters or query parameters.

Did You Know?

Many automation scripts use curl to communicate with REST APIs and cloud services.

Pro Tip

Combine curl with grep, jq (later), or awk to quickly inspect API responses from the terminal.

Answer Key (Instructor Only)

Q1: curl https://example.com

Q2: curl -I https://example.com

Q3: curl -o example.html https://example.com

Q4: curl https://api.github.com

Q5: pwd

Homework

Use curl to download three different web pages and practice viewing headers and saving output to files.

Next Day Preview

Tomorrow you'll learn wget to download files, resume interrupted downloads, and mirror web content.